

1.5 Gbps broadband!

Virgin Media is testing DOCSIS-2 which is powered by a 1.5 Gbps network in London

Fastest graphics on the block

AMD launched Radeon 6990M which it claims is 25 per cent faster than any graphic card in the market

Gaming Laptops

the hinge and then tapers off to a slimmer front. The hinge itself is made of metal and feels solid. The body is made of quality plastic and has a top quality rubberised finish. To the rear, behind the hinge, is a neatly designed scoop in the body that display huge vents with heatsink fins visible for cooling down its innards.

Flip open the heavy-duty lid and the inside is made of sturdy plastic. The bezel around the keypad and keys is brushed metal, while the raised palm rest also sports the same rubberised finish. The G74SX has a huge trackpad that is quite accurate but not precise enough for discerning first-person-shooter gamers. The mouse keys are soft and have deep travel. There are no shortcut keys on the G74SX, other than an ROG button for auto overclocking. The keypad is backlit – a huge help for gaming in dim lighting. The backlighting isn't as good as Alienware's M17x. The G74SX supports 3D stereovision with a 120 Hz display, but glasses were not bundled.

The G74SX features the same Core i7 2630QM that we've seen on a majority of the other notebooks here. This is paired with 16 GB of RAM, and an NVIDIA GeForce GTX560M – the first time we've seen this GPU and it features 384 stream processors, making it a little more potent than the others we've seen. A 1TB hard drive and Blu-Ray drive is also part of the package. The display is

quite crisp and offers good colour and contrast – definitely better than the MSI notebooks, but about at par with the Alienware M11x. *S.T.A.L.K.E.R Call Of Pripyat* saw the biggest improvement



ASUS G74SX

over other notebooks with the GTX460M GPU – 72.3 fps at 1366x768 pixels at maximum settings and everything set to ultra high, and 45.2 fps at 1920x1080 pixels at the same settings. Similarly, *Far Cry 2* was very playable at 46.15 fps at 1920x1080 pixels, with everything set to maximum. With 709 points in Unigine Heaven 2.5, the G74SX is the fastest gaming notebook here.

So what's the flipside? It's very expensive at ₹1,24,990. But it offers a lot too with a 3D-ready display, and a Blu-Ray drive as well as more hard drive space and four times the system RAM. To top that, it's a good performer, though nothing that a sensibly assembled ₹60,000 desktop can't outpace. Still, as far as gaming notebooks go, if you're looking for an extremely upmarket looking, rugged beast with great performance and don't sweat spending top dollar, the ASUS G74SX is a

very good option and wins the Digit Best Performer award.

Alienware M17x: ₹1,59,000

Alienware's M17x is a colossal laptop outweighing even the prodigious G74SX. Large is lovely in this case, and the M17x looks like the result of laborious designing. The outer shape is similar to the M11x. The rubberised finish is extremely well done and looks slick and upmarket. The body inside also has the rubberised finish, except for the bezel around the keypad that is brushed aluminium burnished to a darker hue. The keys are well spaced, and there is just the right amount of feedback from each key. The M17x includes a slightly raised portion on the centre of each key and this extra bit makes typing out long documents a breeze. However, the piece we received had a slight bulge in the centre of the keypad, where the keys seemed a bit more raised – this

– it has a backlit rim around it. Trackpad accuracy is good, but a dedicated mouse is called for. On the top of the keypad, there's a neatly arranged row of backlit buttons for various multimedia functions and to enable or disable Wi-Fi. These are a bit hard to press however. The M17x has a very nice display – good colours, contrast and quite bright. Text appears a bit crisper on the ASUS G74SX's display, but the difference is small. A Blu-Ray drive is included and expected at this price.

With a GTX460M at the graphics helm we didn't expect the M17x to be a scorcher, and it wasn't. It does score 40.4 fps in *Far Cry 2* at maximum settings and full HD resolution, and 40.2 fps in *S.T.A.L.K.E.R Call Of Pripyat* at the same settings. This is 10 per cent or so less than the GTX560M on the ASUS G74SX, and this means the M17x isn't as



Alienware M17x

is definitely due to improper fitment and should be a one-off flaw. Large vents have been provided on the rear to dissipate heat. This is the same chassis that holds an NVIDIA GTX580M, and in lieu of this, such measures for cooling are expected.

The keys are beautifully backlit and so is the trackpad

impressive at running games. And this performance difference continues throughout the benchmarks, where we find the cheaper ASUS outpacing it. Even the MSI GT680R outpaces it at times. Priced at a whopping ₹1,59,000, the M17x is a bit too expensive for the performance it delivers, and the ASUS G74SX trounces it by a decent margin, while costing ₹35,000 less. We recommend you avoid the M17x unless you have really deep pockets and can't resist the appeal of all that backlighting and bling. ■

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